

HAILE GEBRSELASSIE

Haile Gebrselassie had a late kick that he employed in races, coming from nowhere to win. Geb, as he came to be called affectionately, was a master craftsman in long-distance running, finishing his career with two Olympic gold medals, four World Championships titles, and 26 world records in the 10,000m. A 20km run to school—10 km either way carrying books—shaped the ace athlete. Gebrselassie marked his arrival at the 1992 Seoul World Juniors with a hurried finish and gained a double with wins in the 5,000m and 10,000m, the latter coming in true Geb style. He trailed Josephat Machuka for most of the race until he shifted

gears and overtook the Kenyan, who had thought he had the title in his kitty. As the Ethiopian came from behind, Machuka was so enraged that he threw a fist at the overtaking Geb, inviting his disqualification.

As his career blossomed, Gebrselassie used to train 13 times a week, taking off from his gruelling schedules only on Sunday afternoons, averaging anything between 110km and 190km. While he would be trotting out each kilometre at a leisurely pace of six minutes and 15 seconds during the off-season, it would peak up to 4:48 as competitions approached. His training at a high-altitude camp, set at more than 8,000 feet above sea level, only helped Geb measure up to his standards when he competed at sea level. Geb's bow at the Atlanta Games in 1996 also marked a great rivalry with Kenya's Paul Tergat, with the Ethiopian getting to the lead with only a mere 6m left for the finish. At Sydney 2000, as the two men engaged in a fierce battle, Geb confirmed his back-to-back titles quite sensationally on only his last stride.

